areas and a sunroof makes for a lively look for the cabin and its occupants. Up to six airbags are on offer with ABS and ESP and the Slavia even boasts of Multi Collision Braking that is said to prevent potential follow-on collisions in case of an accident. This aside, there is an Electronic Differential System that improves traction while cornering and that brings us to the highlight of the Slavia's ride and handling package.

The Slavia is the second product on the MQB-AO-IN platform after the Kushaq but it is the former that brings out the real dynamic capability of this chassis. Skoda has got the overall balance of the chassis so spot on that it's evident as soon as you take a corner fast. The Slavia turns in deftly, then goes on to hold its designated line as the front sticks on without protesting and the rear comes around nicely to bring a smile of satisfaction to your face. No understeer, no oversteer and simply no drama, the Slavia's chassis brings in predictability and assurance that really encourages the driver to push the car confidently into corners. Enthusiastic driving aside, the Slavia is also surefooted over varied surfaces, with the suspension adept at soaking up the bad roads and managing bigger undulations at high speeds.

Most of this light and nimble handling is also due to the 1.0-litre TSI three-cylinder motor underneath the bonnet that is presumably light. Lest you get the impression that it may be a bit short on power and excitement, it was a joyous revelation to enjoy the response of the engine after the first press of the throttle. There's no turbo-lag to speak of as the engine revs up quickly and feels effortless in acceleration even with passengers on board and tackling rolling roads. The engine response feels sprightly and, coupled with the six-speed manual on test with us, it made for a proper enthusiastic driving feel that tugged at the heart strings just right. ■



LIGHT AND NIMBLE

The Slavia is also available with the 1.5 TSI engine with an option of a 6-speed manual or the 7-speed DSG automatic transmission. The bigger displacement helps generate more power and torque thus translating to better acceleration. The DSG-equipped variant shifts seamlessly while the gear ratios help the engine build revs very quickly



HARVINDER SINGH

The front bucket seats get a two-stage cooling option while the rear seats are supportive and spacious with ample legroom even for taller occupants to stretch their legs and get better under-thigh support. Seating comfort aside, the bright ambience thanks to the black and beige upholstery with generous window



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